Synthesis Document

Connecting assessment findings with stakeholder insights | March 23, 2026

Executive Summary

The Validation Sprint has reached its synthesis phase. Seven stakeholder interviews, combined with pre-engagement research and market analysis, confirm three core findings:

1. **Horicon Bank has strong foundations but needs persona consolidation to make them actionable.** Current segments (~13 across life stages, retail, and business sectors) describe demographics. Validated

personas should describe aspirations. This reframe makes them usable by frontline teams.

2. **"Together. Doing Good." is the brand position with universal internal support and market-ready differentiation.** Every stakeholder independently confirmed this positioning over "The Natural Choice." It works across retail and business, connects to operational proof points (volunteer time, trust seminars, nonprofit partnerships), and aligns with how Milwaukee and Gen Z make banking decisions.
3. **The bank's growth bottleneck is not capability or budget but strategic focus and frontline activation.** The tech stack is solid. The programs exist. The challenge is saying no to some things, simplifying the persona architecture, and getting this strategy into the hands of branch managers and BDOs who talk to customers every day.

This document synthesizes interview findings into validated conclusions and sets up Week 4 Recommendations Brief.

Assessment Validation

What the pre-engagement assessment predicted vs. what interviews confirmed:

Assessment Finding	Interview Validation	Confidence
Segments ≠ Personas	Confirmed by all 7 interviews. Frontline uses life events, not persona language. Cassie: "It just doesn't define anything."	`HIGH`
"Together. Doing Good." > "The Natural Choice"	Universal. Erik uses TDG as primary tagline. Cassie flagged Natural Choice as "questionable." Steve had WTMJ radio "aha moment" on TDG.	HIGH
Senior market = strongest growth engine	Confirmed. 0% failure rate on Glider journeys. Trust seminars convert at scale. Minimal SE Wisconsin competition. Kerry's 2026 focus: Milwaukee senior expansion.	`HIGH`

Assessment Finding	Interview Validation	Confidence
Bank at Work = quick win	Partially confirmed. Required cash incentives to gain traction. Operations was not consulted in design. Scalable with modifications. Rose requested customer list for 90-day priority.	MEDIUM
Nonprofit strategy separate from churches	Confirmed by Rose. $1M deposit from single nonprofit. Board members = HNW individuals with additional banking needs. Church symposium ROI unclear; nonprofit ROI proven.	HIGH
Frontline not using personas	Confirmed by Kerry (19 years): "I can guarantee you... you're not going to get the answers you expect." Cassie (23 years): "Nobody knows what those are." Grace's departure left marketing without activation champion.	HIGH
Youth banking as emerging priority	Independently named by Cassie AND Natalie as 90-day priority. My Money product built. Greenlight competitive threat identified. Gen Z values-based banking (52%) aligns with TDG.	HIGH
Commercial/Business Owner segment missing	Confirmed by Cassie: "We're a pretty big commercial bank. Shouldn't there be some focus on those business owners?" Erik's primary focus. Bank at Work connects here.	HIGH

Persona Consolidation: From Segments to Aspirations

The Shift

Current state: ~13 segments across 5 life stages (M2-M4, Y1, F1), 3 retail personas (School Daze, Fiscal Rookies, Upwardly Mobile), and 5 business sectors (Professional Services, Manufacturing, Real Estate, Agriculture, Nonprofits). **Validated target: 3-4 aspiration-first personas.** This consolidation works because:

- Fewer personas = simpler for frontline to remember and use
- Aspiration-first framing = more intuitive than demographic codes
- Personality-driven messaging = resonates across age, income, and life stage
- Case study precedent: FMHC consolidated 100+ segments to 4 personas using this approach

Four Validated Personas

Persona 1: Established Stewards

Maps to:

Wealthy Achievers (M2), Gliders, Upscale Empty Nesters (M3), Midscale Matures (M4)

Core Aspiration:

Protect and transfer what they've built. Legacy-minded. Relationship-focused. Trust matters more than product features.

Interview Signal:

- Strongest existing relationships in the bank
- 0% journey failure rate on Total Expert Glider program
- Trust seminars converting at scale (100+ attendees, generating new business)
- Kerry: 2026 focus is Milwaukee senior market expansion
- Estate planning and funeral trust partnerships expanding reach

Key Products:

Trust services, estate planning, Golden Free Club, senior programs, estate planning partnerships with local attorneys

Activation Readiness:

HIGH. Programs exist and work. Needs prospect acquisition strategy in Milwaukee (similar to proven Dodge County playbook).

Persona 2: Growing Families

Maps to:

Flourishing Families (F1), School Daze segment

Core Aspiration:

Build a stable foundation while managing competing demands. Busy. Seek convenience and trusted guidance. Focused on children's wellbeing and education.

Interview Signal:

- Natalie identified as needing improvement
- Website needs modernization for this group (mobile-first, education content)
- Mortgage is the bank's strongest product reputation but not translating to top-of-mind awareness
- Missing: education planning content and tools

Key Products:

Mortgage (bank's strength), savings, education planning tools, family financial literacy resources

Activation Readiness:

MEDIUM. Strong mortgage reputation but not leveraged for broader wallet share. Digital experience needs refresh.

Persona 3: First-Generation Builders

Maps to:

Upwardly Mobile (Y1), First-Time Workforce, Fiscal Rookies, Youth (new from interview signal)

Core Aspiration:

Get a real financial footing and make smart first decisions. Values-driven. Open to guidance. Want to build confidence in financial decisions.

Interview Signal:

- Named as 90-day priority by BOTH Cassie AND Natalie independently
- My Money product already built with frictionless age-18 transition
- Greenlight competitive threat identified (pulling early-stage relationships)
- 52% of Gen Z choose banks based on values alignment
- "Together. Doing Good." aligns with Gen Z values-driven banking decisions

Key Products:

My Money checking, first mortgage, savings automation, financial literacy programs, themed digital banking app (in development)

Activation Readiness:

HIGH. Product exists. Values alignment clear. Needs digital activation and financial literacy content to compete with fintechs.

Persona 4: Business Owners

Maps to:

Professional Services, Manufacturing, Real Estate, Agriculture, Nonprofits

Core Aspiration:

Grow the business without outgrowing the bank. Relationship-driven. Need a partner who understands their industry. Concerned about keeping up with bigger banks.

Interview Signal:

- Cassie flagged as missing from original segments
- Erik's primary focus in business development

- Bank at Work program connects here (deposit conversion from business loan customers)
- Vertical IQ intelligence tool positioned to support this

Key Products:

Commercial lending, Treasury Management, Bank at Work employee benefits, Vertical IQ competitive intelligence, industry-specific programs

Activation Readiness:

MEDIUM. Strong BDO team. Bank at Work needs refinement based on Operations feedback. Vertical IQ underutilized in sales conversations.

Aspiration-First Framing: Why It Works

The shift from demographic segmentation to aspiration-first personas makes personas usable by frontline teams:

Old Approach (Demographic)

Segment: "M2 Wealthy Achiever, age 55-74, household income $150K+"

Problem: Frontline doesn't think in demographic codes. Kerry doesn't remember the M2 label.

New Approach (Aspiration)

Persona: "Established Steward. Someone protecting what they've built."

Benefit: Kerry immediately recognizes her best customers and knows what matters to them.

Organizing Principle

The aspiration becomes the organizing principle for messaging, journeys, and product positioning.

Instead of building separate campaigns for each demographic slice, all messaging for Established Stewards rolls up to "protect and transfer what you've built."

Precedent

FMHC consolidated 100+ segments to 4 personas using this approach. Same result: simpler for frontline, more powerful for marketing, easier to measure.

Capability Mapping: What Exists vs. What's Needed

Capability	Established Stewards	Growing Families	First-Gen Builders	Business Owners
Customer Journeys	Active (0% fail on Gliders). Trust seminars converting.	Not built. No mapped moments.	Youth journey framework exists; awaiting approval to activate.	On 3-year wish list. No roadmap started.
Digital Marketing	Events-heavy. Email nurture strong.	Needs mobile-first website. Email underutilized.	Digital ads + geo-tracking needed. Social media gap.	Biz Times advertising started. LinkedIn needed.

Capability	Established Stewards	Growing Families	First-Gen Builders	Business Owners
Frontline Activation	Strong in legacy markets (Kerry, Brenda). Needs Milwaukee prospect list.	Mortgage team capable. Retail branches not activated.	Not activated. Missing peer education strategy.	BDOs active. Commercial branch teams not engaged.
Post-Event Nurture	Exists for seniors (trust seminars). Could be refined.	Missing. Event attendees fall into generic email streams.	Missing. Missing opportunity to convert workshop attendees.	Missing. Networking events don't feed into a process.
Content/Website	Adequate for target audience. Could add more estate planning thought leadership.	Needs modernization. Mobile experience weak. Education content missing.	Needs modernization. Too much industry jargon. Missing peer stories.	Adequate. Could add more industry-specific intelligence.
Tools/Intelligence	Total Expert. Alkami. AnalyzerIQ.	Segmint. Array. Limited personalization.	Total Expert exists. Needs product positioning refresh.	Vertical IQ. Commercial databases. Underutilized in sales.

Brand Position Synthesis: "Together. Doing Good."

All seven stakeholders independently confirmed "Together. Doing Good." as the stronger brand position. Here's the synthesis:

Works Across Retail and Business

Erik confirmed it in business development context. Not just a consumer brand tagline — it works for how Horicon thinks about commercial partnerships too.

Connects to Operational Proof Points

40 hours paid volunteer time for all employees. CHRE virtues. Trust seminars focused on community stewardship. Nonprofit checking program. The tagline isn't marketing fluff — it describes actual culture.

Geographic Advantage

"The Natural Choice" + Horicon Marsh reference has zero meaning in Milwaukee. "Together. Doing Good." is universally understood and resonates.

Gen Z Values Alignment

52% of Gen Z choose banks on values. "Together. Doing Good." speaks directly to this decision framework and differentiates from national banks chasing the same cohort.

Executive Buy-In

Fred built conference presentation around it. Steve had WTMJ radio "aha moment." This isn't just marketing consensus — it's leadership commitment.

Forward-Facing Positioning

130th anniversary positions longevity. "Together. Doing Good." positions purpose. Together = nostalgia + aspiration.

Recommendation: Retire "The Natural Choice" as primary brand position. Keep only in legacy Dodge County marketing where Horicon Marsh has local resonance. All growth-market messaging (Milwaukee, Fox Valley) should lead with "Together. Doing Good."

Strategic Tensions to Resolve in Working Sessions

These tensions are normal for a community bank embracing persona-led growth. They need to be acknowledged and resolved in Week 4 working sessions:

1. Breadth vs. Focus

Community bank DNA says serve everyone. Persona strategy says focus. **Resolution:** Personas don't exclude anyone. They prioritize investment and messaging. A solo mom in Fox Valley still gets a mortgage. But the bank won't build separate mortgage products for every demographic slice.

2. Legacy vs. Growth Markets

Established markets (Dodge County) have proven playbooks. Milwaukee is a new market that needs prospect acquisition, not just customer retention. Same personas, different activation strategies. **Resolution:** One brand, two go-to-market playbooks.

3. Measurement Gap

Strong metrics where Total Expert is deployed (Glider journey = 0% failure rate). No baseline for most marketing activities. **Resolution:** 90-day plan needs measurable KPIs from day one. Can't optimize what you don't measure.

4. Simplification vs. Ambition

Cassie: "Keep it simple, stupid." The bank has too many priorities ("squirrel problem"). Fewer personas = fewer campaigns = deeper impact. **Resolution:** This requires saying no to some things. Clear prioritization in 90-day plan.

What This Sets Up: Week 4 Recommendations Brief

The Synthesis Document feeds directly into the Week 4 Recommendations Brief, which will include:

- **Keep/Change/Explore Framework (Validated Version)** — Updated from initial pre-engagement assessment based on 7 interviews
- **90-Day Priorities with Owners** — Specific actions, assigned owners, success metrics:
  - Senior market Milwaukee expansion (Kerry owner)
  - Bank at Work deposit conversion (Rose + BDO owner)
  - First-Generation Builders youth banking (Cassie + Natalie owners)
  - Content/website modernization (Natalie owner)
- **Messaging Spine for Each Persona** — Core message + supporting messages + proof points. One document all frontline can reference.
- **Activation Playbook** — Tied to existing tools and budget. Not asking for more resources — restructuring what exists.

Path Forward

Week 3 validation is complete. The personas are consolidated. The brand position is confirmed. The strategic tensions are named.

Week 4 is about turning these insights into a working roadmap the entire bank can use.

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